Sánchez brings his migration fight to Brussels

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Presented by EFPIA By GERARDO FORTUNA with ZOYA SHEFTALOVICH and MAX GRIERA CIAO THERE. It’s Gerardo Fortuna, facing a Playbooker’s dilemma this eveni

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CIAO THERE. It’s Gerardo Fortuna, facing a Playbooker’s dilemma this evening: whether to attend Marine Le Pen’s press conference at The Hotel, which promises to be memorable, or head to the opening of Oktoberfest, dubbed by one Commission official yesterday as the second-best thing in Brussels after summer holidays. Tough call.

In today’s Playbook:

— The gloves are off in the European Parliament as MEPs battle for top jobs.

— A fatal shooting near the Parliament has alarmed EU staff already worried about their safety.

— Faces in the crowd: Hilde Vautmans, Giorgia Meloni, Danuše Nerudová, Julien Moinil, Eszter Lakos, Maroš Šefčovič, Biljana Borzan, Roberto Vannacci, François-Xavier Bellamy, Mette Frederiksen, Malik Azmani and more …

On today’s Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian unpack why officials are worried that less development aid could drive support for the far right.

POLITICAL ADVERTISEMENT

A message from EFPIA:Europe has publicly stated its ambition to be a world leader in medical innovation. At the same time, Member States have introduced cost containment measures such as mandatory rebates, meaning industry contributions as a proportion of public pharmaceutical expenditure doubled from 12% to 24% between 2018 and 2023.

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DRIVING THE DAY

READY TO RUMBLE: The EU is expecting Pedro Sánchez to come to the European Council spoiling for a fight on migration, five diplomats and one official told Playbook's Zoya Sheftalovich and me.

The gloves are off: "Of course" there will be a fight, said one senior EU diplomat, adding that it will likely get "quite bloody." Another said they wouldn't be surprised if there's an "intense" debate. They were granted anonymity to speak frankly about their national leaders' expectations ahead of the two-day summit.

The Spanish leader is expected to take on Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni over migration. Taking a stand over the issue is seen as something that will play well with their domestic voter base, two of the diplomats said.

Prime time: Sánchez is behind in the polls ahead of a snap election on Nov. 29, while Meloni faces a tough election next year as far-right challenger Roberto Vannacci gains momentum, one of those diplomats said. "It will be helpful for Sánchez to pick a fight," according to the other EU diplomat. "And it might be helpful for Meloni too."

The ground is laid: The clash comes as EU leaders — and European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen — push for faster returns and tighter border controls. That has put Sánchez, whose government has pushed more liberal migration policies, at odds with the bloc's harder line. The Spanish prime minister came under fire from Meloni and other EU leaders after the mass arrivals in Ceuta.

Sánchez will arrive prepared, two Spanish government officials told our Madrid Playbook colleague Ángel Villarino Perez. He has been briefed through meetings, weekend crisis sessions and ministerial discussions, they said, and will point to results on returns, border management and arrivals. He's expected to defend his record by citing a 74% fall in arrivals on the Atlantic route, which Madrid attributes in part to cooperation with Mauritania and Senegal.

I think I've seen this film before: At the June European Council, Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen steered discussion toward the EU's new returns rules. Sánchez criticized the bloc's hard-line approach, while Meloni backed Frederiksen and attacked Spain's decision to regularize undocumented migrants .

When all is said and done: Diplomats expect the row to produce little tangible change. "They'll say lots of things to each other, and then probably go for a drink after," one said. A lot of work has gone into getting leaders on the same page on the migration pact, the EU official said, meaning they don't expect the broader agreement to be derailed by a diplomatic dust-up.

BIG AND BREAKING

NOW FOR THE HARD PART: EU trade chief Maroš Šefčovič secured a breakthrough deal in Beijing to sharply reduce imports of Chinese hybrid cars — but now faces a tougher task convincing EU leaders that talking to China can deliver more.

SCOOP — HOW THE EPP PLANS TO WIN: The EPP Group will brainstorm how to beat the far right in the 2029 European Parliament election at its retreat in Sicily this morning. Read the internal document circulated to MEPs to spark a policy discussion ⋯ and an annex detailing what the group says it has delivered from its 2024 program .

BUDGET BLIND SPOT: The EU's next budget could make corruption harder to detect, the head of the European Court of Auditors has warned — not exactly the kind of simplification Brussels was aiming for.

READY FOR A FIGHT: Ahead of her trip to Brussels today, French far-right leader Marine Le Pen tells the FT she's gearing up for a "trial of strength" over the EU's budget and powers if she wins the French presidential election.

NO TIME TO FOLD: Donald Trump once said Kyiv had "no cards" to play against Moscow, but its energy strikes on Russian refineries changed that calculation. Now European leaders are urging the U.S. president not to torpedo Ukraine's leverage.

CAN'T BEAT 'EM? USE 'EM: Europe is quietly abandoning its dreams of beating the U.S. and China at building the smartest AI models. The new Brussels mantra: You don't have to own the models if you can put them to work.

NEWS FROM THE VATICAN: Pope Leo XIV has been diagnosed with lung cancer after undergoing surgery to remove part of his right lung yesterday.

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PARLIAMENT'S GAME OF THRONES

PRESSURE COOKER: Tensions are high in the European Parliament as its midterm jobs reshuffle unfolds, Max Griera writes. The EPP, Socialists and Democrats and Renew groups elect their leadership teams next week, while MEPs are fighting over who does what.

Burn short, burn bright: With nobody emerging to rival Renew chief Valérie Hayer for her job, Belgian lawmaker Hilde Vautmans briefly threatened a bid — only to change her mind the next day.

She lashed out at colleagues at a dinner in Strasbourg last week for failing to challenge the group's five-year French dominance and said she would run herself, according to four Renew insiders.

She backed down the day after. "She has no intention of putting forward her own candidacy," her office said.

But it continues: Bids from Malik Azmani and Abir Al-Sahlani have kicked off a crowded contest for the vice chairs, with all eight incumbents also seeking reelection.

Meanwhile, over at the EPP: Manfred Weber is trying to calm his troops after the group descended into all-out war over its vice chairs. He tried to roll over all 10 incumbents, but surprise attempts by Hungary's Eszter Lakos, Portugal's Sebastião Bugalho and Czechia's Danuše Nerudová have upset the balance of power, according to six MEPs and officials.

French guillotine: Weber is lobbying to save close ally François-Xavier Bellamy from being ousted, according to three of the people above, because he is the center-right group's leading French figure ahead of the presidential election. But detractors point to the French delegation's 26% rebellion rate against the group line, the highest in the EPP this term.

Weber's chess: "France is the key," one EPP MEP said, adding Weber needs people "like Bellamy who can deliver with the radical right on our content." Bellamy led on the returns regulation, passed with far-right support. The offices of Bellamy and Weber did not respond to requests for comment.

Over in the S&D, Tuesday's deadline to challenge Iratxe García passed uncontested, and today's vice chair deadline also currently sees no challengers. To head off infighting, the group added a vice chair for its eastern delegations. Biljana Borzan is set to take the post, according to two S&D officials.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Today there's a meeting of the European Parliament's Conference of Presidents … but what is that? It's the top political body in the Parliament, in which the president and the chairs of the political groups meet to set the legislative agenda, decide the responsibilities and membership of committees and delegations, and discuss relationships with other EU institutions and national parliaments. The CoP normally meets twice a month.

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BRUSSELS' BUBBLE OF FEAR

MEAN STREETS: First, EU officials were relocated to Brussels' Northern Quarter, which many consider unsafe . Now, a fatal shooting near the Parliament has brought the concern closer to home, EU staff unions and lobbyists told me.

Right on the doorstep: The person was shot dead around 6 p.m. on Monday on Rue Wiertz, in Ixelles, which is near the Parliament, the European Committee of the Regions and the European Economic and Social Committee. A resident of the street — granted anonymity over fears for their safety — told Playbook they first mistook the gunfire for construction noise. Police cordoned off the street, collected evidence overnight and kept a patrol there until morning. Officers were reassuring but vague when asked if it was safe to stay, the resident said.

The working theory: Investigators suspect a possible settling of scores linked to organized crime, though that remains unconfirmed. "Organized crime in general is a threat for our institutions, but the incident is not related to the EU," Brussels Public Prosecutor Julien Moinil told Playbook.

But it has still alarmed people who work nearby. "We have received many reactions of fear and concern, just as there have been almost every day for our colleagues in the northern neighborhood," said Cristiano Sebastiani of the Renouveau et Démocratie EU staff union.

It's a familiar worry: EU staff raised safety concerns about the Northern Quarter after a stray bullet hit an EU building there last year, outside working hours. In 2023, an EPP parliamentary assistant was shot and injured on Avenue de la Toison d'Or.

“The situation has gotten worse in a way that’s almost visible,” said a lobbyist who works 300 meters from Monday’s shooting. Incidents like this, they said, make “people get paranoid” and wonder whether their street could be next.

DASHBOARD

While Pedro Sánchez prepares to meet EU leaders in Brussels, Spain’s King Felipe VI is due in the country’s North African exclave of Melilla today. The king yesterday visited Ceuta, the scene of the mass arrivals that fueled widespread criticism of Sánchez’s government and aggravated tensions between Spain and Morocco.

7 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

FAMILY FEUD: A rebellion against the Industrial Accelerator Act started with three center-right lawmakers and quickly spread through Ursula von der Leyen’s own political family. Here’s how a small EPP mutiny became a big headache for the EU’s flagship industry law .

GIVE BIG OIL AN INCH ⋯ The Commission is preparing to delay its methane rules by a year under pressure from the fossil fuel industry, Washington and EU capitals. Big Oil’s response? Thanks, but we’d like more.

START STUDYING: The date that thousands of aspiring EU officials have been waiting for is finally here: The first round of AD5 competition tests will take place Nov. 9-13.

HANDS OFF 1: The Committee of the Regions, which votes today on a new Agenda for Cities, will warn that plans to dismantle the Commission’s regional policy department (DG REGIO) risk sending a “deeply worrying political signal.”

HANDS OFF 2: Fifty-eight MEPs want von der Leyen to stop Washington’s sanctions against the International Criminal Court, calling the sweeping measures a “foreign attack on EU territory.”

AWAY FROM HOME: Ukraine’s top football team, Shakhtar Donetsk, is playing its home Champions League fixtures at Chelsea’s Stamford Bridge. Ali Walker talked to the club’s top executives about why they’re playing for much more than on-field success.

LAGARDE’S BOOK CLUB: Christine Lagarde encouraged journalists to buy her memoir at an ECB press conference. Now the bank’s staff committee wants to know whether the sales pitch broke its ethics rules.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mainly sunny, with a high of 18C.

HAPPENING TODAY: POLITICO’s European Resilience Summit kicks off this morning at 9 a.m. On the agenda: everything from the EU’s economic security and digital autonomy to energy resilience and defense readiness. Tune in here to watch and follow in our live blog .

Don’t miss: At 1:45 p.m. our Chief EU Correspondent Zoya Sheftalovich will sit down with the EU’s Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius to discuss Europe’s security divide.

Watch until the end: At 4:20 p.m., POLITICO’s Antoaneta Roussi will moderate a closing discussion about what tradeoffs Europeans are ready to make to be more resilient. She’ll speak to Commission Executive Vice President Roxana Mînzatu’s head of cabinet Alina Ujupan, Achim Wambach, president of the Leibniz Centre for European Economic Research (ZEW), and Steven Everts, director of the European Union Institute for Security Studies (EUISS). Full lineup .

SPOTTED ⋯ at the EU-Turkey Business Summit: Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič; Turkish Trade Minister Ömer Bolat; Eleftheria Psaraki, taxation policy officer for the European Commission; Mechthild Wörsdörfer, deputy director-general at DG Energy; Leopold Griessler, policy officer at Volkswagen Group; the FT’s Andy Bounds; and POLITICO’s Jordyn Dahl.

WORDS OF WISDOM: João Vale de Almeida, a former EU ambassador to the U.K. and the U.S., will deliver the EU Diplomacy Lecture at the College of Europe in Bruges tomorrow, where he’ll weigh in on the EU foreign policy clash between the Commission and the EEAS. “The last thing the EU needs now is a turf war around its external action. This would only embolden our adversaries and competitors,” he told Playbook. His book, “The Divorce of Nations: A Diplomat’s Inside View as the Global Order Collapses,” will hit bookstores in Italy on Friday.

ANTIQUE HUNT: As autumn descends on Brussels, Playbook’s Sebastian Starcevic argues there are few activities cozier and more fall-coded than antiquing. Fortunately, Brussels is replete with shops full of hidden gems and curios, from tchotchke-hawking holes in the wall to pricey-but-fun-to-look-at galleries ⋯ and we’ve listed just a few of our favorites below.

Reliek, on Rue de l’Enseignement, is packed with a well-curated assortment of art, furniture and curios, with its owner driving across Belgium and France for the best estate sale finds. This means the offering changes week to week.

Go for a wander: Basically all of Rue Blaes in Brussels’ trendy Marolles district is an antique lover’s paradise, but don’t miss Passage 125, which sprawls out over four whole floors overflowing with a chaotic jumble of trinkets and oddities.

There’s a dog: Costermans in Sablon, which has been operating for almost 200 years, offers a more refined, museum-like experience, with Old Master paintings, chandeliers, furniture and sculptures. There’s also a lovely cafe and courtyard attached, where you can order the tuna melt and say hi to the sleepy German Shepherd.

A few honorable mentions: Les Petits Riens in Châtelain ⋯ Dandelion in Saint-Gilles ⋯ 10gallery in Ixelles ⋯ and the flea market at Place du Jeu de Balle.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz will make a statement to the Bundestag at 2 p.m., looking to send a clear message on Ukraine, China and the EU budget before tomorrow’s European Council.

Paris: The National Assembly will vote today on how much France should contribute to the EU , while far-right leader Marine Le Pen is in Brussels making the case for deep cuts.

Madrid: Spain’s tough new lobbying laws have been repealed just 22 days after coming into effect, amid pushback from business associations .

London: Andy Burnham will welcome Volodymyr Zelenskyy to Downing Street after last night declaring Britain’s “rock-solid” support for Ukraine’s resistance against Russia.

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AGENDA

— Tripartite Social Summit, co-chaired by Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Council President António Costa. Participants will discuss the EU’s long-term budget and the single market, starting at 3 p.m. Press conference around 5:15 p.m. Watch live .

— French presidential candidate Marine Le Pen is in Brussels for the Patriots for Europe’s pre-Council meeting. Press conference at 7:30 p.m.

— NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte visits Estonia, where he’ll meet President Ülle Madise, Prime Minister Kristen Michal, Foreign Affairs Minister Margus Tsahkna and Defense Minister Martin Herem. Press conference with Michal at 11:25 a.m. Rutte gives a speech at Tallinn University of Technology at 1:20 p.m. Watch live .

— German Chancellor Friedrich Merz makes a statement to the Bundestag on the upcoming European Council meeting at 2 p.m., followed by a debate.

— Costa attends a meeting of the Multiannual Financial Framework Contact Group in the European Parliament, presided over by European Parliament President Roberta Metsola, at 9:30 a.m.

— Metsola presides over the Conference of Presidents at 4 p.m.

— Costa meets Metsola at 10:30 a.m. ⋯ Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos at noon ⋯ and Catalan regional government President Salvador Illa i Roca at 12:45 p.m.

— POLITICO’s European Resilience Summit. Program . Live blog .

— International AI Summit in Dublin, with addresses by Commission Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen, Innovation Commissioner Ekaterina Zaharieva and Commissioner Michael McGrath. Agenda .

— EU Trade Policy Day, with addresses by DG TRADE Director-General Ditte Juul Jørgensen at 9:10 a.m. and Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič at 3 p.m.

— EU High Representative Kaja Kallas meets Dutch Interior Minister Pieter Heerma in Brussels ⋯ and attends a session of the Foreign Affairs Committee of the German Bundestag in Berlin.

— The European Week of Regions and Cities continues, with Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto participating in a session on modernizing cohesion policy. Watch live .

— Space Commissioner Andrius Kubilius and Crisis Management Commissioner Hadja Lahbib address an event on space policy and disaster risk management at 3 p.m. Watch live .

— Coreper I meets at 8:30 a.m.

— Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen attends the European Farmers Congress and meets the presidents of COPA and COGECA in Stockholm.

— Housing Commissioner Dan Jørgensen holds an implementation dialogue on housing supply.

BIRTHDAYS

MEPs Mireia Borrás Pabón, Isabelle Le Callennec and Daniel Freund; Jyrki Katainen, former Finnish PM and European commissioner; former MEP Constanze Krehl; Better Politics Fund's Gauri van Gulik; David Bencsik, from the Hungarian Prime Minister's Office; Will Garton from the U.K. Ministry of Housing; Andrea Campbell, from the European Broadcasting Union.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere, Sebastian Starcevic and Gregorio Sorgi. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producer Hugh Kapernaros.

POLITICAL ADVERTISEMENT

**A message from EFPIA:Across Europe, the growing use of mandatory rebates requires pharmaceutical companies to return money to the state when public spending on medicines exceeds agreed budgets. Mandatory industry refunds to governments have risen from around 12% to 24% of pharmaceutical revenues since 2018, reflecting a wider trend of structural underbudgeting. These policies operate like a tax, with no guarantee that savings delivered on existing or older medicines are reinvested in newer ones.It is unrealistic to expect greater investment in Europe and faster access to new treatments while simultaneously demanding the lowest possible prices and highest government clawback rates. Europe needs to make a choice: medicines budgets should evolve sustainably, taking account of economic and population growth, ageing, disease burden and opportunity costs. **

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